ARE COLLEGE GAMEDAY GUEST PICKERS ANY GOOD?

October 18, 2026 · Data: Cole's Gameday Blog archival picks

Abstract

College GameDay guest pickers chose the winner on 61.47% of 2,554 graded picks (1,570 wins, 984 losses) across 220 guests from 2004 to 2026, and no guest with a meaningful sample is clearly better or worse than that average. Joe Namath and Joel McHale lead guests with 25 or more picks at 21 of 31 (67.7%), but a 95% interval around either record includes the overall average. Steve Young's 10-for-10 on October 17, 2026 had a 1-in-130 chance under a simple model, and it is one of two perfect ten-pick appearances in the archive, which is a plausible count (11% chance). The spread of guest records, the season trend and the results for repeat guests all match what luck alone would produce; whether guests beat betting favorites could not be tested because the data lacks point spreads.

1. Introduction

Every Saturday morning a celebrity guest picks the day's marquee games on ESPN's College GameDay, and fans keep score. This paper asks whether those guests are actually good at predicting games and who the best of them is.

Three questions drive the analysis:

1. Who ranks highest on career accuracy, total correct picks, and perfect appearances, once sample size is taken into account?
2. How unusual is Steve Young's perfect ten-for-ten appearance next to the historical record?
3. Do guests differ in skill, or do their records look like the product of chance?

2. Data and methods

Data. The source is Cole's Gameday Blog archival picks page (gamedaycole.com/archival-picks), which lists every graded guest pick as of 2026-10-18. The working dataset has 2,554 rows, one per pick, with week, date, guest, the pick ("X over Y") and the result. The archive's own aggregate is 1,570 wins and 984 losses, and the row-level data reproduces it exactly.

Definitions.

- **Season:** the football season, so January bowl games count toward the prior year.
- **Appearance:** one guest in one season and week label (numbered weeks, B for bowls, FCS, and week 0).

- **Perfect appearance:** a full slate of 8 or more picks with every pick correct. Partial appearances with 1 to 5 recorded picks are excluded because the archive notes that some older appearances lack complete picks.

Statistics. Intervals around each guest's win rate use the Wilson 95% interval. Tail probabilities use the binomial distribution at the overall rate of 61.47%. Guest-level dispersion is checked with a chi-square statistic on standardized records. The expected count of perfect appearances comes from simulation, treating each pick as an independent 61.47% event.

Sample sizes. The most picks recorded for any one guest is 45, so the planned thresholds of 50 and 100 picks are empty. Thresholds of 25, 20 and 15 picks leave 8, 19 and 32 guests.

3. All-time leaderboard

Namath and McHale top the 25-pick board at 67.7%, and Alex Rodriguez tops the 15-pick board at 83.3%. None of these leaders is statistically separable from the 61.47% average, and Rodriguez's 20 of 24 has the smallest tail probability among them (p = 0.019).

Guest	Correct / picks	Win %	Appearances	Perfect appearances
Joe Namath	21 / 31	67.7	3	0
Joel McHale	21 / 31	67.7	3	0
Keegan-Michael Key	29 / 45	64.4	4	0
Vince Vaughn	22 / 35	62.9	3	0
Eric Church	21 / 34	61.8	3	0
Eddie George	19 / 31	61.3	4	0
Charles Barkley	23 / 41	56.1	8	0
Mark Cuban	14 / 29	48.3	3	0

Guests with 25 or more picks, sorted by win percentage. Keegan-Michael Key has the most correct picks (29) and the most picks (45) of anyone.

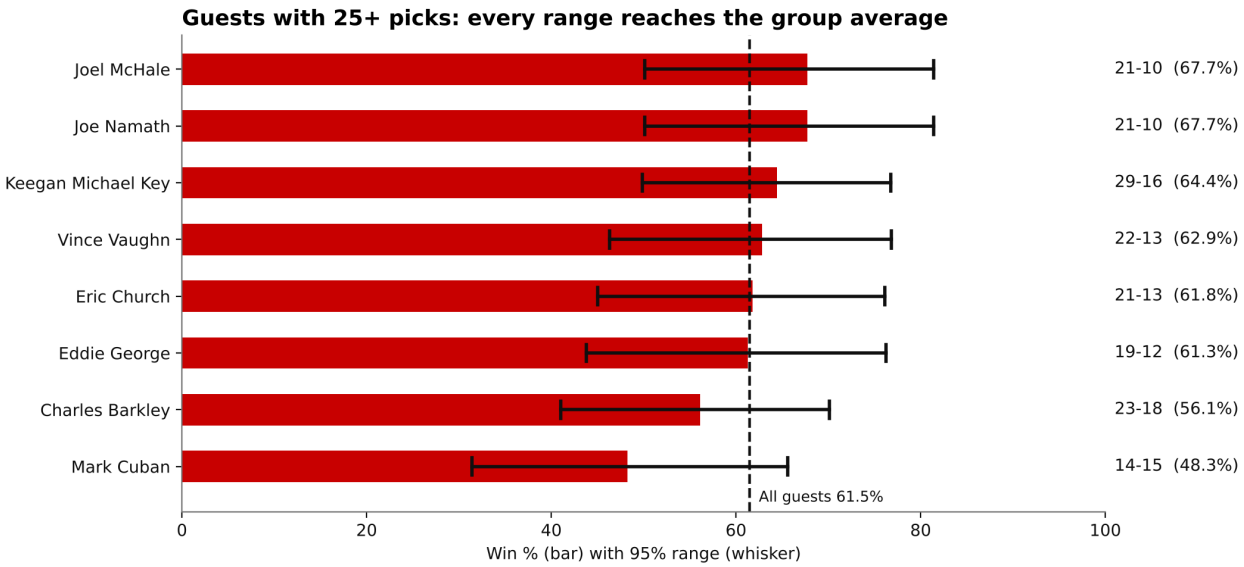


Figure 1. Win percentage with 95% range for guests with 25+ picks.

Among guests with 15 to 24 picks, the leaders are Alex Rodriguez (20 of 24), Bo Jackson (17 of 22), Luke Bryan (16 of 22), Trae Young (13 of 18) and Lane Kiffin (16 of 23). Rob Riggle, Willie Robertson and Nathan Followill share the worst records at 7 of 19 (36.8%).

Two data caveats apply. The archive's official record for Joel McHale in 2023 differs from the picks it could identify, and Charles Barkley's 2004 appearance is incomplete.

4. Steve Young's perfect appearance

A ten-for-ten appearance has a 0.77% chance (about 1 in 130) when each pick is an independent 61.47% event, and the archive shows it is rare but not unprecedented.

Seventy-five appearances have exactly ten picks. Two went 10 for 10: Bubba Watson in 2013 and Steve Young on October 17, 2026. A luck-only model expects 0.6 such appearances, and two or more would occur 11% of the time. Average score in these appearances is 6.3 correct against 6.1 expected.

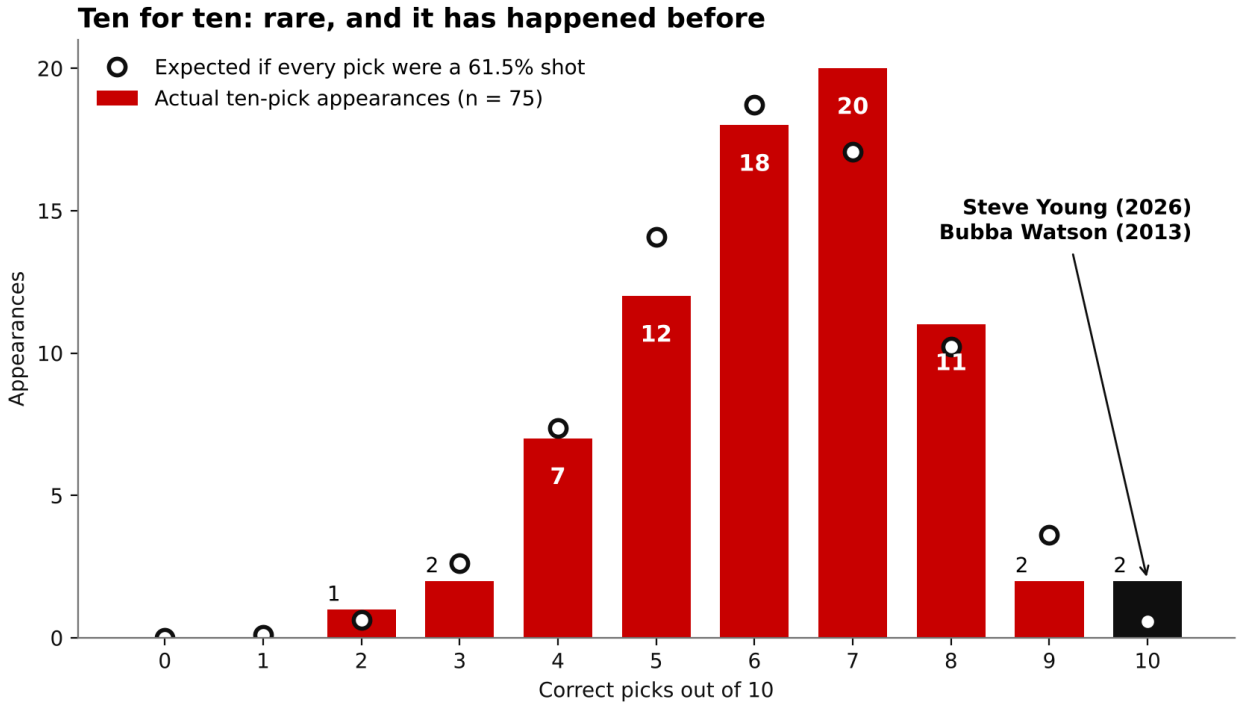


Figure 2. Correct picks in the 75 appearances with exactly ten picks, against the luck-only expectation.

Alex Rodriguez went 12 for 12 in 2017, the longest perfect slate on record, and Jase Robertson went 9 for 9 in 2014. Across all 229 appearances with 8 or more picks, five were perfect where luck predicts about two (simulated probability of five or more: 4.7%). Perfect slates therefore appear slightly more often than independent picks would produce, although five events is a small count. Young's final pick, UCLA over Wisconsin, is dated October 16 in the archive while his other nine are dated October 17.

5. Skill versus luck

Guest records spread out as luck predicts. Thirteen of 220 guests fall outside the 95% limits around 61.47% (5 above, 8 below), where chance alone puts about 11. Among the 8 guests with 25 or more picks, the chi-square statistic is 3.9 on 7 degrees of freedom (p = 0.80), so their records are, if anything, less dispersed than luck would give.

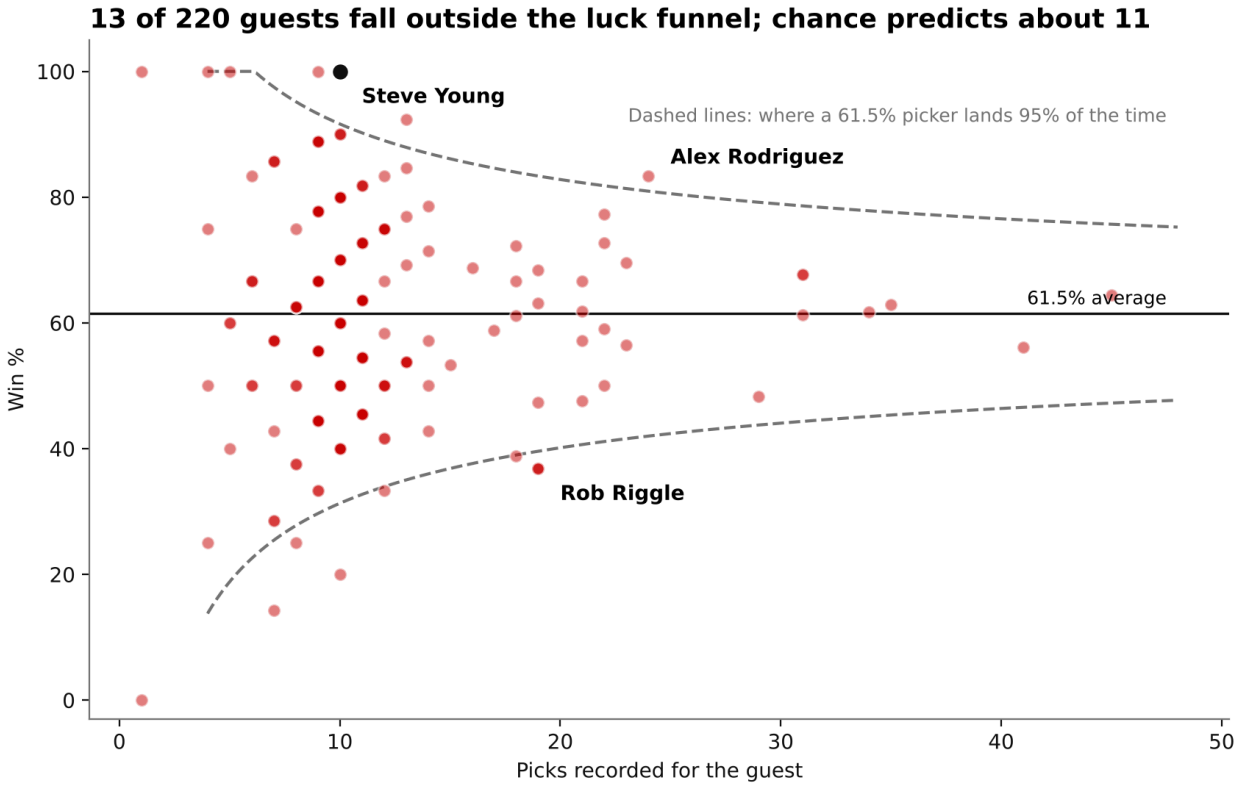


Figure 3. Each dot is one guest; dashed lines mark where a 61.5% picker lands 95% of the time.

Test	Result
Accuracy by season	No trend: seasons with 25 or more picks range from 55.6% (2012) to 67.1% (2017), and the slope is +0.15 points per season (p = 0.45).
Repeat guests	Win rate falls with each appearance: 62.1% (first), 60.9% (second), 56.7% (third), 48.8% (fourth or later, 43 picks). The later groups are small.
Worst single appearances	Eric Stonestreet (2011) and Willie Robertson (2014) each went 1 for 9.

The worst collapses are the mirror image of the best slates, and both sit within the range chance produces over 279 appearances.

6. Limitations

- **No betting lines.** The dataset has no spreads, so it cannot say whether guests add anything over simply picking the favorite. This is the most important open question, because a 61.47% hit rate is only impressive relative to how often favorites win in these games.
- **Small samples per guest.** The median guest made 10 picks, which cannot separate a 60% picker from a 70% picker.
- **No game difficulty adjustment.** A guest picking heavy favorites is treated the same as one picking underdogs.
- **No guest categories.** Comparing former athletes with other guests, or testing school loyalty, requires affiliations that are not in the data.

- **Independence assumed.** Picks on the same day may be correlated (shared knowledge of a week's slate), which would make perfect slates somewhat more likely than the simple model says.
- **Archive gaps.** Some older appearances lack complete picks, and the archive documents source-specific grading for a few cases.

7. Conclusion

Guest pickers win about three picks in five, and the data show no reliable difference among them. The best all-time record depends on the sample-size threshold, and every leader's interval includes the group average. Steve Young's perfect appearance is a genuine rarity, comparable to two earlier ten-pick or longer perfect slates. The next step is to add pregame spreads so that guest accuracy can be compared with the favorite's win rate.

Sources

- Cole's Gameday Blog, archival picks: https://gamedaycole.com/archival-picks/ (viewed as of 2026-10-18 through the supplied Celebrity Record files and the starter workbook).